

Schools of Buddhism — MCQ Solutions

Seed 17762885289694100775; each question has four synchronized option-specific explanations.

MCQ 1. What the Four Noble Truths are doing

With reference to the Four Noble Truths (catvāri āryasatyāni), consider the following statements.

1. The second truth supplies a causal account of how suffering is produced.
2. The third truth is an independent article of faith unconnected with the second.
3. The fourth truth prescribes the discipline by which the causal chain is interrupted.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: it retains statement 2, which severs cessation from origination, whereas cessation is precisely what follows once a dependently produced effect loses its condition.
- B: Correct: the second truth gives the dependent arising of suffering and the fourth gives the discipline that breaks it, which is exactly why the third truth is an entailment rather than a hope.
- C: Incorrect: keeping statement 2 while dropping statement 1 removes the causal account that alone makes the path in statement 3 intelligible as a therapy.
- D: Incorrect: statements 1 and 3 are sound, but including 2 contradicts them, since the third truth is derived from the conditionality asserted in the second.

Examiner trap: Presenting the four truths as a numbered list rather than as one causal circuit read forward and backward loses the analytical marks the directive is actually testing.

MCQ 2. Three denials that must not be merged

Buddhism is classified as unorthodox (nāstika), as non-theistic and as anti-substantialist. These three descriptions respectively rest on its rejection of

- A. renunciation as a way of life, the authority of teachers, and the conventional usefulness of ordinary speech
- B. rebirth across lives, the possibility of liberation, and the validity of inference as a means of knowing
- C. the moral law of action, the practice of meditation, and the reality of the external world as such
- D. Vedic scriptural authority, the explanatory necessity of a creator, and a permanent self behind experience

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: renunciation and teachers are central to the tradition, and conventional speech is expressly preserved under the doctrine of conventional truth.
- B: Incorrect: Buddhism affirms rebirth without a soul, affirms liberation as its whole purpose, and accepts inference as one of its two means of valid knowledge.
- C: Incorrect: Buddhism affirms moral consequence and meditative discipline, and only some Buddhist schools question the external world, so none of these grounds the three labels.
- D: Correct: the three labels track three distinct denials — of Vedic authority, of a required creator, and of a permanent self — and confusing them produces most classification errors in scripts.

Examiner trap: Translating *nāstika* as "atheist" collapses the Veda criterion into the creator criterion and makes *Sāṃkhya* and *Mīmāṃsā*, which are non-theistic yet Veda-accepting, unclassifiable.

MCQ 3. What the practical Middle Path actually rejects

In its practical sense, the Middle Path (*madhyamā pratipad*; Pali: *majjhimā paṭipadā*) is best described as

- A. a distinct disciplined route that rejects both sensual indulgence and self-mortification because neither removes craving
- B. an instruction to suspend judgement between rival philosophical positions until further evidence becomes available
- C. a rule of social conduct that regulates the relations between the monastic community and lay supporters
- D. a proportionate blend of moderate enjoyment with moderate austerity, adjusted to the temperament of the practitioner

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: both extremes are rejected on the same diagnostic ground — indulgence feeds craving while mortification exhausts the practitioner without touching it — and the replacement is the eightfold training.
- B: Incorrect: suspension of judgement is a sceptical stance, whereas the Middle Path is a definite prescription with eight named factors.
- C: Incorrect: monastic and lay relations belong to disciplinary literature, not to the doctrinal content of the first-sermon framework.
- D: Incorrect: the middle is not the average of the extremes; it is a third, positively specified training whose test is causal efficacy against craving rather than balance.

Examiner trap: Describing the Middle Path as moderation imports an Aristotelian mean and conceals the fact that Buddhism rejects the extremes for failing a causal test, not for being immoderate.

MCQ 4. Grouping the eight factors

The eight factors of the Noble Eightfold Path (*āryāṣṭāṅgamārga*) are classically grouped under three trainings. Right speech, right action and right livelihood belong to

- A. wisdom (*prajñā*), because each of them presupposes a correct view of conditioned things
- B. a fourth training of faith, which the tradition adds separately for lay practitioners of the path
- C. meditative discipline (*samādhi*), because each of them is practised only during formal periods of sitting
- D. ethical discipline (*śīla*), because each of them regulates outward conduct that renews the conditions of craving

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: wisdom covers right view and right intention; conduct factors presuppose wisdom but are not classified under it.
- B: Incorrect: the classical grouping is threefold, and no separate training of faith is added to the eightfold scheme.

- C: Incorrect: meditative discipline covers right effort, right mindfulness and right concentration, none of which is a conduct factor.
- D: Correct: speech, action and livelihood are the conduct factors, and their function is to stop renewing the conditions in which craving is generated.

Examiner trap: Listing the eight factors ungrouped reads as recitation; the grouping into wisdom, ethical discipline and meditative discipline is itself the analytical content the examiner is looking for.

MCQ 5. The doctrinal middle

The doctrinal sense of the Middle Path consists in the rejection of

- A. eternalism (śāśvatavāda) and annihilationism (ucchedavāda), in favour of conditioned continuity without a permanent bearer
- B. realism about external objects and idealism about consciousness, in favour of a neutral monism of events
- C. inference as an independent means of knowledge and testimony as a derived one, in favour of perception alone
- D. asceticism as a monastic ideal and ritual as a lay one, in favour of a purely contemplative discipline

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: dependent origination denies an unchanging bearer without denying causal continuity, which is exactly the middle between the two named extremes.
- B: Incorrect: the realism–idealism dispute divides the four Buddhist schools internally and is not what the doctrinal middle names.
- C: Incorrect: that restriction describes the Cārvāka position on knowledge, whereas Buddhism accepts perception and inference alike.
- D: Incorrect: this restates the practical middle inaccurately and omits the metaphysical pair the doctrinal middle actually rejects.

Examiner trap: Treating no-self as a form of annihilationism reverses the doctrine, since annihilationism denies causal continuity while no-self denies only the permanent bearer of it.

MCQ 6. The formula of dependent origination

The standard formula of dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) is significant for Buddhist soteriology chiefly because

- A. it identifies a first cause from which the entire series of conditioned phenomena can be shown to proceed
- B. it establishes that every effect pre-exists in its material cause and is merely manifested when conditions mature
- C. it demonstrates that the relation between cause and effect is a matter of habitual expectation rather than of nature
- D. it states positive conditionality and negative conditionality together, so that cessation is built into the principle itself

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the doctrine explicitly declines to identify an absolutely first cause, and the wheel image encodes that refusal.
- B: Incorrect: the pre-existence of the effect in the cause is the Sāṃkhya thesis of satkāryavāda, which Buddhism does not hold.
- C: Incorrect: reducing causation to habitual expectation is a Humean position, whereas Buddhism treats conditionality as law-like and objective.
- D: Correct: the four clauses pair presence with arising and absence with cessation, which is why the third Noble Truth follows from the principle rather than being added to it.

Examiner trap: Quoting only the arising half of the formula silently discards the cessation half, which is precisely the half that makes dependent origination a doctrine of liberation.

MCQ 7. The three marks and their scope

With reference to the three marks (trilakṣaṇa; Pali: tilakkhaṇa), consider the following statements.

1. Impermanence and unsatisfactoriness are standardly predicated of conditioned formations.
2. The mark of no-self is applied more widely than the other two.
3. Impermanence in the early teaching is verbally identical with the later thesis of momentariness.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1, 2 and 3
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 2 and 3 only

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: statement 3 erases the distinction between the early teaching of impermanence and the stronger scholastic thesis of one-moment duration.
- B: Incorrect: statements 1 and 2 are correct, but statement 3 conflates an early teaching with a later radicalisation of it.
- C: Correct: the standard formula restricts the first two marks to conditioned formations while applying not-self more widely, which is why the unconditioned status of cessation is not thereby contradicted.
- D: Incorrect: it keeps the false identification in statement 3 and drops the accurate scope claim in statement 1.

Examiner trap: Inferring from universal impermanence that cessation of conditioned suffering must itself be one more momentary event ignores its classification as unconditioned in important Buddhist traditions.

MCQ 8. The order of the chain

In the twelve-link sequence (dvādaśa-nidāna), the correct order of the links immediately following name-and-form (nāma-rūpa) is

- A. feeling, contact, six sense-bases, craving
- B. six sense-bases, contact, feeling, craving
- C. craving, feeling, six sense-bases, contact
- D. contact, six sense-bases, craving, feeling

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: feeling arises from contact and cannot precede it, which reverses the very junction at which the path intervenes.
- B: Correct: name-and-form conditions the six sense-bases, which condition contact, which conditions feeling, which conditions craving.
- C: Incorrect: this inverts the whole segment and would make craving prior to the sensory conditions that generate it.
- D: Incorrect: contact presupposes the sense-bases through which it occurs, so it cannot precede them, and feeling cannot follow craving.

Examiner trap: Reversing feeling and craving destroys the doctrine's practical bite, because the entire discipline of mindfulness is located precisely in the gap between them.

MCQ 9. Why the chain is not fatalism

Buddhists deny that the twelve-link chain entails fatalism primarily because

- A. the chain is a purely symbolic representation with no claim to describe the actual conditions of rebirth or suffering
- B. every link may be broken at any point by an act of divine grace conferred independently of the practitioner's effort
- C. the links classified as present causes remain open to alteration, so present practice changes what is subsequently produced
- D. the sequence describes only the experience of unenlightened persons and does not apply to disciplined practitioners

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: treating the chain as merely symbolic would remove the causal claim that makes cessation possible at all.
- B: Incorrect: grace conferred by a deity has no place in a system that treats a creator as explanatorily unnecessary.
- C: Correct: on the three-life arrangement the past causes and present results are already produced, while craving, clinging and becoming remain open, which is where discipline operates.
- D: Incorrect: the chain describes the general conditions of cyclic existence, and a practitioner is precisely someone working within it rather than exempt from it.

Examiner trap: Presenting only the three-life reading suggests a fixed chronology; adding the present-process reading is what shows the chain to be immediately practical.

MCQ 10. The criterion behind momentariness

The Buddhist thesis *yat sat tat kṣaṇikam* is grounded on the prior claim that

- A. whatever is perceived by the senses must be composed of parts and is therefore liable to decomposition
- B. whatever is real is capable of producing an effect, so that reality is identified with causal efficacy
- C. whatever is denied by the opponent must be affirmed by the proponent if the debate is to remain intelligible
- D. whatever is described by a general term must be a conceptual construction rather than an ultimately real entity

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: decomposition of composites is a different argument and would not by itself yield the strict one-moment thesis.
- B: Correct: the equation of the real with what is capable of an effect is the premise from which the two-horned dilemma against permanence is launched.
- C: Incorrect: this is a debating convention and has no role in establishing an ontological thesis.
- D: Incorrect: this states the exclusion theory of meaning, which concerns universals rather than the temporal duration of the real.

Examiner trap: Deriving momentariness directly from dependent origination skips the causal-efficacy premise and leaves the derivation demanded by the 2020 question logically incomplete.

MCQ 11. The two horns

In the Buddhist argument against a permanent efficient cause, the horn of simultaneity (yaugapadya) presses the objection that

- A. a permanent entity producing its whole effect at once leaves nothing available for later production
- B. a permanent entity would require a second permanent entity to destroy it when its function is complete
- C. a permanent entity would have to be perceived as enduring, whereas perception presents only momentary phases
- D. a permanent entity would be unable to enter into any relation with the auxiliary conditions that surround it

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: if the complete power operates at once, later production has no remaining ground, which is exactly the simultaneity horn.
- B: Incorrect: this states the separate argument from destruction, which denies that perishing needs an external destroyer.
- C: Incorrect: the argument is inferential rather than perceptual, since no one claims to perceive momentary phases directly.
- D: Incorrect: the inability to relate is not asserted; the argument concedes auxiliaries and then shows that admitting them is fatal in a different way.

Examiner trap: Presenting momentariness as directly observed misrepresents an argument that works by eliminating the permanent alternative rather than by reporting an experience.

MCQ 12. Closing the Nyāya escape route

Nyāya replies that a permanent substance acts only when auxiliary conditions (sahakārin) are present. The Buddhist counter-dilemma is that

- A. auxiliary conditions are themselves permanent, so the reply merely postpones the original difficulty by one step
- B. auxiliary conditions cannot be perceived, so their postulation violates the Buddhist restriction to two means of valid knowledge
- C. auxiliary conditions belong to the category of quality, which cannot be causally responsible for the production of a substance
- D. either the permanent thing already possesses the power, making auxiliaries idle, or the auxiliaries supply it, making the permanent thing redundant

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Nyāya does not claim that auxiliaries are permanent, so the reply misses the actual position it is attacking.
- B: Incorrect: auxiliaries are ordinary observable conditions, so no epistemological restriction is violated by admitting them.
- C: Incorrect: this borrows Vaiśeṣika category language and does not correspond to any step of the Buddhist argument.
- D: Correct: the sahakāri-anapekṣā dilemma exhausts the alternatives, leaving the permanent entity either unnecessary or altered by acquiring a power it lacked.

Examiner trap: Omitting the auxiliary-conditions reply and its closure leaves the momentariness argument looking like an assertion, because the dilemma is the point at which the realist alternative is actually eliminated.

MCQ 13. How continuity survives momentariness

Under momentariness, the appearance of an enduring object is explained by

- A. an underlying substance that persists while its qualities are successively replaced by similar qualities
- B. an act of divine sustenance that maintains resemblance between successive states of the world

- C. a causal series (santāna) whose successive members are sufficiently similar to be treated as one thing
- D. a permanent witnessing consciousness before which the succession of states is continuously displayed

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: an underlying persisting substance is precisely the Nyāya position the Buddhist argument has just eliminated.
- B: Incorrect: divine sustenance is unavailable in a system that treats a creator as explanatorily unnecessary.
- C: Correct: continuity is carried by causal succession plus similarity, which is what the flame and stream illustrations are used to convey.
- D: Incorrect: a permanent witness is the Advaitic device, and importing it would abandon no-self altogether.

Examiner trap: Explaining continuity by quietly reintroducing a subtle self converts the Buddhist answer into the position it was designed to refute; the device is always the series, never a bearer.

MCQ 14. The exhaustive analysis of the person

The philosophical force of the five-aggregate (pañca-skandha) analysis lies in the fact that

- A. the enumeration is claimed to be exhaustive, so that failure to find a sixth item is failure to find a self
- B. the analysis is presented as a provisional teaching device that a more advanced practitioner may discard
- C. the aggregates are ranked hierarchically, with consciousness serving as the owner of the remaining four
- D. each aggregate is shown to be permanent in substance while impermanent in its successive modes

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: the doctrine stands or falls on exhaustiveness, since a further category would restore the very owner the analysis claims cannot be found.
- B: Incorrect: the analysis is doctrinally central rather than provisional, and it is the standard route to the printed no-self thesis.
- C: Incorrect: consciousness is one aggregate among five and is examined and found not-self along with the others.
- D: Incorrect: permanence of substance with changing modes is the Jaina definition of the real, which Buddhism explicitly rejects.

Examiner trap: Defining no-self without enumerating the aggregates removes the argument and leaves only the conclusion, which is why such answers read as assertion rather than demonstration.

MCQ 15. What the chariot analogy establishes

In the chariot analogy of the Milinda-pañha, the philosophical point is that

- A. the chariot is wholly unreal, so that anyone who uses the word is making a straightforward factual mistake
- B. the term functions correctly as a designation without naming any further entity beyond the parts and their arrangement
- C. the chariot is identical with the sum of its parts arranged in a heap, so that the arrangement contributes nothing
- D. the chariot possesses a distinct nature that emerges from the parts and thereafter exists independently of them

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the analogy preserves ordinary usage, since the chariot can still be driven, purchased and repaired.
- B: Correct: the analogy makes a semantic point — a term can be true without being referential to an additional item — and that is what protects the conventional person.
- C: Incorrect: a mere heap is expressly denied to be a chariot, which is why arrangement and function are part of the account.
- D: Incorrect: an emergent independent nature would be a *svabhāva*, which the analogy is designed to exclude.

Examiner trap: Using the chariot to prove that the person is unreal overshoots the analogy and invites the charge that Buddhism cannot account for practice, ethics or refuge.

MCQ 16. Moral consequence without a permanent self

The Buddhist formula that the later stage is "neither the same nor another" (*na sa eva na cānyaḥ*) is philosophically necessary because

- A. strict identity is asserted at the conventional level while strict difference is asserted at the ultimate level
- B. strict identity is a Nyāya doctrine while strict difference is a Sāṃkhya doctrine, so both must be rejected as non-Buddhist
- C. strict identity would reinstate eternalism while strict difference would make the fruit fall on an unrelated recipient
- D. strict identity would preserve responsibility while strict difference would preserve impermanence, so both must be affirmed together

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the two-truths distinction is not used to distribute identity and difference across levels in this way.
- B: Incorrect: the rejection is argued from internal consequences, not from the schools that happen to hold the positions.
- C: Correct: the formula is a middle precisely because each extreme destroys one of the things Buddhism wishes to keep — impermanence on one side, responsibility on the other.
- D: Incorrect: affirming both together would be straightforwardly contradictory, whereas the formula denies both in favour of causal continuity.

Examiner trap: Locating moral quality in outward action rather than in intention (*cetanā*) removes the aggregate in which Buddhism actually places moral responsibility.

MCQ 17. What cessation of conditioned suffering is

Cessation of conditioned suffering (*nirvāṇa*; Pali: *nibbāna*) is most accurately described as

- A. the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion, and thereby the ceasing of the process that produces suffering
- B. the complete annihilation of the individual, understood as the destruction of a substance that formerly existed
- C. the attainment by the liberated self of a permanent state of undisturbed bliss in a region beyond the world
- D. the merging of individual consciousness into a universal consciousness from which it had been temporarily separated

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: the three fires are what is extinguished, and what ceases is the conditioned production of suffering rather than an entity.
- B: Incorrect: annihilation presupposes a substance to annihilate, and no such substance was ever admitted.
- C: Incorrect: this reinstates both the self and a place, each of which the doctrine expressly declines to posit.

- D: Incorrect: merging into a universal consciousness is an Advaitic formulation and is precisely the crypto-Advaita reading the tradition resists.

Examiner trap: Treating the classification of nirvāṇa as unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) as evidence for an eternal self confuses being outside the dependent series with being a substance.

MCQ 18. The internal relation of the Three Jewels

In the Buddhist account of the Three Jewels (Triratna), the internal relation among Buddha, Dharma and Saṅgha is best stated as

- A. a hierarchy in which the community confers authority on the teaching and the teaching confers authority on the teacher
- B. three independent objects of devotion, each sufficient on its own to secure liberation for the practitioner
- C. a functional triad in which the teacher discovered the path, the teaching liberates, and the community preserves and transmits it
- D. a symbolic triad with no doctrinal content, retained only because the formula of refuge is ritually convenient

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the direction of origin runs from the teacher through the teaching to the community, even though access today runs the other way.
- B: Incorrect: the three are interdependent in function, and treating each as independently sufficient misstates the structure of refuge.
- C: Correct: this states both the origin relation and the transmission relation, which is exactly what a question on internal relation is asking for.
- D: Incorrect: the triad carries substantive doctrinal content, since what liberates is identified as the teaching rather than as devotion to a person.

Examiner trap: Arguing that refuge presupposes a soul misses the reply that the refuge-taker is the conventional designated person, which is all that being conditioned by instruction requires.

MCQ 19. Vaibhāṣika realism and its cost

The Vaibhāṣika affirmation that dharmas of the past, present and future have some mode of existence is best explained as

- A. an inference from the impossibility of partless atoms combining to form perceptible gross objects
- B. an acceptance of an eternal substance underlying the momentary states in which it successively appears
- C. a concession to Mahāyāna criticism that the momentary ontology of the earlier schools was too austere
- D. a device required to keep past acts able to bear future fruit and to give every cognition a genuine object

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the atom argument is a Yogācāra weapon against external realism and does not support the three-times thesis.
- B: Incorrect: no eternal substance is admitted; what is claimed is a mode of existence for dharmas across the three times.
- C: Incorrect: the thesis belongs to the Sarvāstivāda tradition on its own account and is not a response to Mahāyāna pressure.
- D: Correct: both the karmic relation and the cognitive relation need two relata, and extending existence across the three times is how Vaibhāṣika supplies them.

Examiner trap: Reading sarvam asti as eternalism ignores the further Vaibhāṣika claim that only present dharmas possess the distinctive present efficacy.

MCQ 20. The Sautrāntika argument

Sautrāntika concludes that external objects are known only inferentially because

- A. external objects are ultimately unreal, so any cognition of them must be a construction of the mind alone
- B. the senses are unreliable instruments whose deliverances must always be corrected by scriptural testimony
- C. the object-moment has already ceased when the cognition it caused arises, so cognition can only bear its form
- D. universals cannot be perceived, and therefore no cognition of a general object can ever be perceptual

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Sautrāntika is a realist school that affirms external objects and disputes only the mode of access to them.
- B: Incorrect: scriptural correction of the senses plays no part in the argument, which turns entirely on momentariness and causal order.
- C: Correct: momentariness plus the requirement that a cause precede its effect yields a time-gap, so cognition presents a form from which the object is inferred.
- D: Incorrect: this concerns universals rather than external particulars and belongs to the theory of exclusion.

Examiner trap: Classifying Sautrāntika as sceptical about the external world confuses a claim about access with a claim about existence and destroys its role as the realist half of the 2024 contrast.

MCQ 21. The three natures

In Yogācāra, the imagined (*parikalpita*), dependent (*paratantra*) and perfected (*pariṇiṣpanna*) natures are best understood as

- A. three distinct realities arranged in ascending order, the lowest being annihilated when the highest is realised
- B. three descriptions of one dependent flow — as falsely taken, as actually running, and as truly seen
- C. three types of cognition, corresponding respectively to perception, inference and testimony
- D. three stages of meditative attainment, corresponding to concentration, insight and final absorption

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: treating them as three entities multiplies realities and invites the objection that Yogācāra abandons its own economy.
- B: Correct: the three natures describe the same flow under a superimposed duality, in its actual conditioned running, and as realised free of that superimposition.
- C: Incorrect: the Buddhist means-of-knowledge school admits only two means, and the three natures are not a classification of them.
- D: Incorrect: they are an analysis of how objectification arises and is removed, not a graded ladder of meditative states.

Examiner trap: Presenting the three natures as three worlds makes liberation look like the acquisition of a new object rather than the withdrawal of a superimposition.

MCQ 22. From dependence to emptiness

The Mādhyamika derivation of emptiness (*śūnyatā*) from dependent origination turns on the premise that

- A. whatever possesses intrinsic nature (svabhāva) would exist through itself and would therefore not depend on conditions
- B. whatever is cognised must be identical with the cognition of it, so that no object stands outside awareness
- C. whatever is expressed by a word must be a construction, so that only the ineffable particular can be ultimately real
- D. whatever is composite must eventually decompose, so that no composite thing can be counted as ultimately real

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: independence is built into the very concept of intrinsic nature, so dependence excludes it and emptiness follows immediately.
- B: Incorrect: the identity of object and cognition is a Yogācāra thesis that Mādhyamika criticises as a further reification.
- C: Incorrect: this states the Buddhist theory of the unique particular and belongs to epistemology rather than to the emptiness derivation.
- D: Incorrect: decomposition of composites is a weaker argument and would not touch simples, which the emptiness thesis also covers.

Examiner trap: Omitting the two truths from an emptiness answer makes the doctrine read as nihilism, which is exactly the misreading Nāgārjuna warns against with the image of the wrongly seized snake.

MCQ 23. The label that is not a name

Which of the following statements about Buddhist tradition-labels is accurate?

- A. Theravāda is one surviving school with the Pali canon, while Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika belong to the Sarvāstivāda world
- B. Theravāda, Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika are three names for a single school opposed to a uniform Mahāyāna system
- C. "Hīnayāna" was the shared self-designation of the early schools before Mahāyāna adopted a different name
- D. Vaibhāṣika and Yogācāra are Theravāda formations, while Sautrāntika and Mādhyamika are Mahāyāna formations

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: this states the placements accurately and keeps the Pali canonical tradition distinct from the Sanskrit, Chinese and Tibetan transmission of Sarvāstivāda material.
- B: Incorrect: the three are distinct, with different canons and doctrines, and Mahāyāna is itself internally diverse rather than uniform.
- C: Incorrect: the label was applied by Mahāyāna authors to disciple-vehicle traditions and was not adopted by them as a self-description.
- D: Incorrect: it scrambles the placements, since Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika are non-Mahāyāna while Yogācāra and Mādhyamika are Mahāyāna.

Examiner trap: Writing "Hīnayāna (Theravāda)" repeats a polemical classification as though it were a neutral synonym and simultaneously misplaces two of the four philosophical schools.

MCQ 24. Store-consciousness is not a self

Store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) differs from the self (ātman) rejected by Buddhism because it is

- A. confined to the present life and destroyed at death, so that it cannot support rebirth or moral consequence
- B. imperceptible to ordinary cognition and therefore knowable only through the testimony of an authoritative teacher

C. a conditioned and continually transforming stream that carries seeds rather than an unchanging substantial owner

D. shared among all sentient beings as a single cosmic reservoir in which individual experience is temporarily located

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: it is invoked precisely to explain continuity across death, which a stream destroyed at death could not do.
- B: Incorrect: the difference is ontological rather than epistemic, and testimony is not an independent means of knowledge in this school.
- C: Correct: being conditioned and transforming is precisely what distinguishes it from a permanent bearer, which is why it does not violate no-self.
- D: Incorrect: a single cosmic reservoir would be closer to an absolute consciousness and would abandon the school's anti-substantialism.

Examiner trap: Calling store-consciousness a Buddhist soul concedes the Madhyamaka objection that Yogācāra reifies consciousness, without noticing that Yogācāra itself insists on its conditioned character.

MCQ 25. The type of negation

Madhyamaka denial of all four corners of the catuṣkoṭi avoids contradiction because the negation employed is

- A. provisional, so that the denials are withdrawn once the opponent has been silenced in the course of debate
- B. non-implicative (prasajya-pratiṣedha) and scoped to things taken as possessing intrinsic nature, so no fifth thesis is installed
- C. merely rhetorical, so that the denials are not intended as claims and carry no philosophical commitment at all
- D. implicative (paryudāsa-pratiṣedha), so that denying each corner asserts the remaining alternatives in turn

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the denials are not withdrawn, and the "no thesis" claim is defended precisely as a stable position.
- B: Correct: the negation withdraws a malformed question rather than asserting an alternative, and the scope restriction is what makes this coherent.
- C: Incorrect: the denials are genuine philosophical claims about the incoherence of intrinsic nature, not debating rhetoric.
- D: Incorrect: implicative negation would indeed assert alternatives and would make the fourfold denial self-contradictory.

Examiner trap: Writing that Nāgārjuna rejects logic mistakes a scoped non-implicative negation for irrationalism and forfeits the reply to the self-refutation charge.

MCQ 26. Buddhist means of knowledge

The Buddhist restriction to two means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) is argued from

- A. the scriptural authority of the Buddha, whose word settles disputes about the correct enumeration of knowledge-sources
- B. the claim that means of knowing are fixed by the distinct kinds of objects to be known
- C. the practical observation that comparison and testimony rarely yield certainty in ordinary human affairs
- D. the impossibility of establishing invariable concomitance, which restricts valid knowledge to immediate perception

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the school argues the point philosophically and does not treat testimony as an independent authoritative means.
- B: Correct: Buddhist epistemologists correlate perception with unique particulars and inference with constructed generalities, so object-types delimit the *pramāṇas*.
- C: Incorrect: the argument is not statistical or practical but structural, resting on a division of possible objects.
- D: Incorrect: denying invariable concomitance and restricting knowledge to perception is the Cārvāka position, not the Buddhist one.

Examiner trap: Describing Buddhist logic as Nyāya logic with a shorter list ignores that it rests on momentary particulars, exclusion and the denial of an enduring knower.

MCQ 27. Exclusion and its critics

The objection that the exclusion theory of meaning (*apoha*) is circular holds that

- A. excluding non-cows presupposes already knowing what a cow is, so the account assumes what it set out to explain
- B. exclusion presupposes momentariness, which has not itself been established independently of the theory of meaning
- C. exclusion cannot apply to negative terms, since there is no positive class from which the exclusion could be made
- D. exclusion applies only to words and not to concepts, so it cannot explain the generality present in thought itself

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: this is the standard charge, and Dharmakīrti's reply appeals to shared causal capacity rather than to a prior grasp of a universal.
- B: Incorrect: momentariness is argued independently through causal efficacy and is not the target of the circularity charge.
- C: Incorrect: negative terms are not the difficulty raised by Kumāriḷa Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara against the theory.
- D: Incorrect: the theory is expressly about conceptual generality as well as about words, so the restriction is not one it accepts.

Examiner trap: Declaring the circularity objection dissolved overstates the reply, since many critics hold that causal convergence explains classification without explaining positive determinate cognition.

MCQ 28. Reading the silence

The most defensible reading of the Buddha's refusal to answer the undeclared (*avyākṛta*) questions is that

- A. he lacked the relevant knowledge, which is why the tradition preserves the questions without preserving answers
- B. the questions were philosophically trivial and were dismissed because they had no bearing on any doctrine
- C. the questions were reserved for advanced disciples and were answered privately outside the public discourses
- D. the questions are both unconvective to liberation and defective in presupposing a substantial self or world

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the agnostic reading fits poorly with the strong positive teaching of suffering, its origin, its cessation and the path.
- B: Incorrect: the questions are treated as seriously misleading rather than trivial, since answering them would concede an extreme.
- C: Incorrect: no doctrine of a private answer is offered, and the arrow parable gives a stated reason for the refusal itself.

- D: Correct: combining the therapeutic reason given in the arrow parable with the presuppositional defect is the reading best supported by the sources and by no-self.

Examiner trap: Reading the fire-going-out simile as a hidden self departing in some direction inverts its point, which is that directional predication lapses once the sustaining conditions cease.

MCQ 29. The comparison most often written wrongly

In comparing Buddhism with Jainism, which of the following is accurate?

- A. Both accept Vedic authority, but Jainism restricts it to ethics while Buddhism restricts it to meditative practice
- B. Both affirm a permanent self, but Jainism treats it as omniscient while Buddhism treats it as momentary in nature
- C. Both reject a creator God, but Jainism affirms a real conscious soul while Buddhism denies any permanent self
- D. Both deny the soul, but Jainism explains continuity by karmic matter while Buddhism explains it by a causal series

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: both traditions are classified as unorthodox precisely because they reject Vedic authority.
- B: Incorrect: Buddhism affirms no permanent self at all, so the shared premise of the option is false.
- C: Correct: the shared rejection of a creator is genuine, and the decisive contrast is that the Jaina jīva is real and intrinsically conscious while Buddhism denies any such substance.
- D: Incorrect: its first clause is false, since Jainism affirms the soul emphatically, even though its account of karmic matter is correctly described.

Examiner trap: Saying that Buddhism and Jainism both deny the soul is the single most frequently penalised comparison error in the topic, because it erases the pluralist realism that defines Jainism.

MCQ 30. Why cessation follows

Which inference correctly connects dependent origination with the third Noble Truth?

- A. Because suffering is unreal, insight merely reveals that it never occurred.
- B. If suffering occurs only while its sustaining conditions obtain, removing those conditions entails cessation.
- C. Because liberation is guaranteed by the Buddha's authority independently of causal practice.
- D. Because every effect must return into a permanent material cause.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Buddhism diagnoses suffering as dependently real, not sheer illusion.
- B: Correct: The negative conditionality clause makes cessation an implication of the same law that explains arising.
- C: Incorrect: The inference is causal and practical, not an appeal to authority.
- D: Incorrect: This imports a substantial causal theory rejected by Buddhism.

Examiner trap: Stating cessation as faith rather than reverse causal analysis disconnects the second and third truths.

MCQ 31. Three readings of twelve links

Which account best relates the three-life, present-process and structural readings of the twelve links?

- A. Only the three-life reading is canonical; the others deny rebirth.
- B. The structural reading turns the links into twelve simultaneous substances.
- C. The three readings are compatible lenses on cross-life, present-process and structural dependence.
- D. The present-process reading replaces causal explanation with phenomenological description.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Present-process and structural readings explain operation without cancelling rebirth.
- B: Incorrect: Structural recurrence is conditional, not substantial or necessarily simultaneous.
- C: Correct: The readings answer different temporal and analytical questions without requiring one rigid chronology.
- D: Incorrect: It retains causal dependence at an immediately observable scale.

Examiner trap: Treating the pedagogical three-life allocation as the only meaning makes intervention look fatalistically delayed.

MCQ 32. Conditionality without linearity

A student says dependent origination must be a single chain beginning with a first event. What is the best correction?

- A. Every link is only a metaphor, so no causal order is asserted.
- B. Conditional dependence allows cyclic and reciprocal patterns without requiring any first cause.
- C. All twelve links occur simultaneously and therefore have no temporal uses.
- D. The chain begins with ignorance, which is therefore an unconditioned first cause.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: The account is explanatory and soteriological, not merely figurative.
- B: Correct: Conditionality is broader than a one-directional chronological series.
- C: Incorrect: Some readings are structural, but temporal and cross-life readings remain legitimate.
- D: Incorrect: Ignorance is itself conditioned and beginningless in saṃsāric analysis.

Examiner trap: Calling ignorance the first cause converts a pedagogical starting point into the metaphysical origin Buddhism refuses.

MCQ 33. Impermanence is not yet momentariness

Why does the inference 'conditioned things change; therefore each lasts exactly one moment' require an additional premise?

- A. Momentariness follows only from scriptural testimony and cannot be argued.
- B. Ordinary impermanence permits enduring but changing continuants; strict momentariness requires the causal-efficacy dilemma against permanence.
- C. Impermanence applies only to minds, whereas momentariness applies only to bodies.
- D. The early teaching accepts a permanent substance beneath changing qualities.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Buddhist logicians provide an explicit causal argument.
- B: Correct: The stronger temporal conclusion does not follow from change alone.
- C: Incorrect: Neither doctrine is divided along a mind-body boundary.
- D: Incorrect: That is precisely the substantialism Buddhist analysis rejects.

Examiner trap: Using anitya and kṣaṇikavāda as interchangeable labels hides the contested inferential step.

MCQ 34. The succession horn

What does the succession horn (krama) argue against a permanent cause?

- A. A permanent cause cannot coexist with any auxiliary conditions.
- B. Successive production is impossible because time is unreal.
- C. If it produces successively, every later effect must already exist in the cause.
- D. Successive effects require differing causal performance, contradicting a wholly unchanged cause.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: The Buddhist grants auxiliaries provisionally and then tests their role.
- B: Incorrect: The argument does not depend on denying conventional time.
- C: Incorrect: That is a satkāryavāda issue, not the Buddhist horn.
- D: Correct: Different temporal performances are evidence of change, not of an inert permanent power.

Examiner trap: Answering only the simultaneity horn leaves the permanent cause an untested succession escape.

MCQ 35. Perishing without a destroyer

Why do Buddhist momentarists deny that a distinct external destroyer is required for each thing's cessation?

- A. A conditioned event exhausts itself in arising, without awaiting an external destroyer.
- B. Because destruction is a permanent substance present inside every object.
- C. Because non-existence acts backwards in time upon the thing.
- D. Because perception directly observes an infinitesimal destruction-particle.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: Conditioned arising exhausts itself without a second destructive cause.
- B: Incorrect: This reifies destruction and contradicts momentariness.
- C: Incorrect: Absence is not treated as an efficient cause acting retroactively.
- D: Incorrect: The thesis is inferential, not observation of such a particle.

Examiner trap: Positing a destroyer merely shifts the question to what destroys the destroyer and weakens the self-exhaustion argument.

MCQ 36. Memory without a witness

Which mechanism best explains memory in a momentary stream without postulating an enduring knower?

- A. A later cognition inherits an earlier cognition's disposition and actualizes it as memory.
- B. Memory is invalid and therefore needs no causal explanation.
- C. The numerically same cognition remains latent and later reappears.
- D. A permanent self stores representations while mental events change.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: Causal inheritance links episodes without numerical identity.
- B: Incorrect: Its epistemic status does not remove the phenomenon requiring explanation.
- C: Incorrect: A persisting cognition contradicts strict momentariness.
- D: Incorrect: That is the Nyāya-style solution Buddhism rejects.

Examiner trap: The phrase 'same memory' easily smuggles in the enduring owner whose necessity is under dispute.

MCQ 37. Conventional personal identity

On the strongest Buddhist account, what makes the person at a later time conventionally the same person?

- A. Possession of one immutable consciousness common to every life.
- B. Mere bodily resemblance, even without causal connection.
- C. Causal continuity supporting memory and accountability grounds conventional personal identity.
- D. Numerical identity of all five aggregates across time.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: This is the substantial self denied by no-self.
- B: Incorrect: Similarity without causal continuity could link unrelated individuals.
- C: Correct: Conventional identity is dependence-based continuity rather than ultimate self-sameness.
- D: Incorrect: The aggregates themselves change and cannot provide strict identity.

Examiner trap: Saying 'only a convention' must not be allowed to mean arbitrary naming without causal constraints.

MCQ 38. Action and responsibility

Which formulation best preserves Buddhist moral responsibility under no-self?

- A. Volition qualifies action, while the later causal stream inherits its consequences.
- B. A subtle agent survives only for moral cases and disappears in meditation.
- C. The act belongs to no one, so karmic fruit is allocated impersonally at random.

D. Responsibility is impossible because only numerical identity can ground desert.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: Cetanā plus causal continuity does the work ordinarily assigned to a substantial agent.
- B: Incorrect: An ad hoc moral self contradicts the general no-self thesis.
- C: Incorrect: Dependent continuity, not randomness, connects action and fruit.
- D: Incorrect: This states the objection while ignoring the Buddhist continuity reply.

Examiner trap: Confusing absence of a metaphysical owner with absence of intentional agency makes Buddhist ethics unintelligible.

MCQ 39. What perception reaches

In Buddhist epistemology, why is the svalakṣaṇa assigned to perception rather than conceptual judgement?

- A. It is the permanent substance supporting changing qualities.
- B. It is a universal present identically in many instances.
- C. It is a linguistic meaning fixed by reliable testimony.
- D. Perception reaches a causally efficacious particular; exclusion supplies conceptual generality.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: That is a realist substance ontology rejected by Buddhist logicians.
- B: Incorrect: Repeatable universals are precisely what apoha avoids reifying.
- C: Incorrect: Language operates conceptually and does not present the bare particular.
- D: Correct: Perception and inference differ because their objects differ.

Examiner trap: Calling svalakṣaṇa an individual member of a real universal class imports the Nyāya ontology the theory opposes.

MCQ 40. How apoha forms a concept

How can the word 'cow' function, according to apoha, if no real universal cowhood is admitted?

- A. It denotes a separately existing universal perceived in each cow.
- B. It guides cognition by excluding non-cows among particulars that converge in relevant causal capacities.
- C. It refers to one privileged archetypal cow copied by all others.
- D. It has no cognitive content and works only through social habit.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: That is the Nyāya account being rejected.
- B: Correct: Negative differentiation can organize practical generality without a shared entity.
- C: Incorrect: No archetypal particular explains general predication.
- D: Incorrect: Apoha offers determinate exclusion, not semantic emptiness.

Examiner trap: Reducing apoha to the bare phrase 'not non-cow' without explaining causal convergence makes the theory look vacuous.

MCQ 41. Creator as an unnecessary posit

Which Buddhist criticism most directly targets a creator introduced to explain the ordered causal world?

- A. Creation is refuted because the Vedas never mention a deity.
- B. Complete conditional explanation makes a creator redundant; intervention revives partiality problems.
- C. Any first cause must be material and therefore visible.
- D. A creator is impossible solely because no being can be morally good.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Buddhism does not ground the argument in Vedic silence.
- B: Correct: The critique combines redundancy with the dilemma of morally unequal creation.
- C: Incorrect: The objection does not depend on perceptibility or materiality.
- D: Incorrect: The critique concerns explanatory role, not a blanket denial of goodness.

Examiner trap: Merely writing 'Buddhism is atheistic' substitutes a label for the actual explanatory argument.

MCQ 42. Four historical labels

Which statement keeps early Buddhism, Theravāda, 'Hīnayāna' and Mahāyāna historically distinct?

- A. Theravāda is an early lineage, Hīnayāna a polemical label, and Mahāyāna diverse movements.
- B. Early Buddhism is simply the doctrinal system of later Vaibhāṣika.
- C. Mahāyāna is one school with a single ontology opposed to the Pali canon.
- D. Theravāda and Hīnayāna are neutral synonyms for every non-Mahāyāna school.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: The labels denote different historical, polemical and institutional classifications.
- B: Incorrect: Vaibhāṣika is a later Sarvāstivāda scholastic formation.
- C: Incorrect: Yogācāra and Madhyamaka differ profoundly within Mahāyāna.
- D: Incorrect: The polemical label is neither neutral nor coextensive with Theravāda.

Examiner trap: Using Hīnayāna as a chronological bucket erases both self-designation and doctrinal plurality.

MCQ 43. Vaibhāṣika direct realism

What makes Vaibhāṣika realism 'direct'?

- A. Only consciousness exists, but it projects an external-seeming object.
- B. Universals are directly perceived as permanent entities.

C. Vaibhāṣika perception directly takes a present external particular as its object.

D. All three times are perceived simultaneously in one cognition.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: That is closer to Yogācāra, not Vaibhāṣika.
- B: Incorrect: Buddhist realism here concerns dharmas, not Nyāya universals.
- C: Correct: The contrast concerns the immediate object of cognition.
- D: Incorrect: Sarvāstivāda does not imply simultaneous direct perception.

Examiner trap: Equating realism with belief in permanent substances misses Vaibhāṣika's momentary direct objects.

MCQ 44. Sautrāntika seeds

What role do 'seeds' play in a Sautrāntika account?

- A. They are Platonic forms copied by momentary particulars.
- B. Seeds are transmitted causal capacities explaining delayed effects without persisting dharmas.
- C. They are microscopic permanent substances stored in the soul.
- D. They are external objects directly perceived before cognition arises.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: The account is causal, not exemplar-based.
- B: Correct: Seed language replaces persisting entities with transmitted causal potency.
- C: Incorrect: No soul or permanent seed-substance is admitted.
- D: Incorrect: Seeds explain dispositions, not direct realism.

Examiner trap: Treating a seed as a tiny enduring object reproduces the very persistence problem it was introduced to solve.

MCQ 45. Co-cognition

What does the Yogācāra co-cognition (sahopalambha) argument claim?

- A. Awareness is a permanent substance while blue is momentary.
- B. Blue is inferred from awareness because it always precedes awareness.
- C. Every perceiver shares numerically the same awareness of blue.
- D. Blue and blue-awareness are never separately apprehended, weakening independent subject-object duality.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Yogācāra does not secure the argument by making awareness permanent.
- B: Incorrect: The argument stresses inseparable apprehension, not temporal priority.
- C: Incorrect: It does not posit a universal consciousness.

- D: Correct: Inseparability in cognition undercuts independently established duality.

Examiner trap: The argument does not prove that a private ego creates objects; it targets the evidential basis of dualism.

MCQ 46. Dream argument

What conclusion can the Yogācāra dream argument establish without overreaching?

- A. Only the dreamer's permanent self is ultimately real.
- B. Nothing whatsoever exists because dreams are unreal.
- C. Dream-like appearance shows that seeming externality does not prove an external correlate.
- D. Waking and dream cognitions are identical in every practical respect.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: That conclusion directly violates no-self.
- B: Incorrect: The argument challenges external-object inference, not all conditioned cognition.
- C: Correct: The argument defeats a claimed inference from appearance to externality.
- D: Incorrect: Yogācāra can distinguish causal regularity without conceding external objects.

Examiner trap: Using the dream analogy alone to prove total nihilism goes far beyond its evidential target.

MCQ 47. Atom-composition pressure

What is the distinct burden of Yogācāra's atom argument against an external gross object?

- A. It argues that waking experience lacks the regularity found in dreams.
- B. The argument attacks whether partless atoms can combine, or whether divisible atoms can remain ultimate.
- C. It argues that an external cause has already ceased before its cognition arises.
- D. It argues that all cognition belongs to one permanent cosmic mind.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Dream reasoning concerns evidence from appearance, not atomic composition.
- B: Correct: The atom argument targets the coherence of external composition rather than the timing of cognition.
- C: Incorrect: That is the separate time-gap argument.
- D: Incorrect: Yogācāra does not require an eternal universal subject.

Examiner trap: Combining atom and time-gap reasoning in one proposition conceals their independent argumentative burdens.

MCQ 48. Not private idealism

Which feature most clearly prevents Yogācāra from collapsing into 'my private mind invents everything'?

- A. External atoms secretly remain as causes of every representation.

- B. A single eternal world-mind guarantees everyone the same objects.
- C. Truth is whatever an individual can imagine consistently.
- D. Constructed subjects and shared karmic seeds allow stable experience without private-ego idealism.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Retaining external atoms abandons representation-only.
- B: Incorrect: That would import an absolute consciousness not required by the account.
- C: Incorrect: Causal constraint, not private choice, orders experience.
- D: Correct: The school denies independent subject and object together and explains order causally.

Examiner trap: Calling Yogācāra subjective idealism makes the empirical ego more real than the school allows.

MCQ 49. How prasaṅga works

In Madhyamaka debate, what is the point of prasaṅga?

- A. To prove a positive Madhyamaka substance by syllogism.
- B. To suspend all reasoning because logic is conventional.
- C. To assert all four alternatives of the catuṣkoṭi simultaneously.
- D. Prasaṅga exposes consequences of svabhāva without establishing a rival essence.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Prasaṅga avoids installing such a counter-essence.
- B: Incorrect: It uses reasoning rigorously at the conventional level.
- C: Incorrect: Madhyamaka rejects, rather than jointly asserts, reified corners.
- D: Correct: The method is consequence-based deconstruction, not sceptical silence.

Examiner trap: 'No thesis' does not mean 'no argument'; it means no self-grounded metaphysical counter-position.

MCQ 50. Why emptiness is not nihilism

Which proposition best states Madhyamaka's anti-nihilist reply?

- A. Emptiness permits dependent functioning; sheer nonexistence could not function.
- B. Some privileged dharmas retain intrinsic nature to ground the rest.
- C. Emptiness is a subtle substance that supports changing phenomena.
- D. Ultimate truth cancels causation, ethics and language as false.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: Dependence and emptiness are mutually implicating, not mutually destructive.

- B: Incorrect: Any such exception would contradict universal emptiness.
- C: Incorrect: Emptiness itself is empty and cannot be a substrate.
- D: Incorrect: Convention remains indispensable to practice and teaching.

Examiner trap: The nihilism charge gains force only when conventional efficacy is omitted.

MCQ 51. Escalation among schools

Which sequence correctly represents a major inter-school escalation?

- A. Madhyamaka returns to Vaibhāṣika direct realism after refuting Yogācāra.
- B. Realism yields to representation, then representation-only, then emptiness of consciousness.
- C. All four schools accept the same ontology and differ only in meditation.
- D. Vaibhāṣika denies objects; Sautrāntika restores them; Yogācāra makes them permanent; Madhyamaka makes them mental.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Madhyamaka does not restore self-existing dharmas.
- B: Correct: Each step radicalizes criticism of what the prior position still reifies.
- C: Incorrect: Their disputes concern objects, cognition and intrinsic nature.
- D: Incorrect: Every transition is reversed or distorted.

Examiner trap: A four-school table that lacks the argumentative transitions is taxonomy, not philosophical comparison.

MCQ 52. Direct and indirect realism

Two cognitions have the same phenomenal form. How would Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika differ about their external object?

- A. Vaibhāṣika directly perceives externals; Sautrāntika infers them from caused representations.
- B. Vaibhāṣika infers the object while Sautrāntika directly perceives it.
- C. Both directly perceive a universal instantiated in the object.
- D. Both deny external objects but disagree about store-consciousness.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: The existence claim is shared while the access claim differs.
- B: Incorrect: This simply reverses the positions.
- C: Incorrect: Neither adopts Nyāya universal realism in this form.
- D: Incorrect: Both are realist schools and need not invoke ālaya.

Examiner trap: Calling Sautrāntika idealist confuses representational access with denial of the external cause.

MCQ 53. Yogācāra and Madhyamaka

What is the sharpest Madhyamaka criticism of a Yogācāra formulation that makes consciousness ultimately real?

- A. It admits too many external atoms.
- B. It denies all conventional cognition and practice.
- C. It accepts a permanent personal soul.
- D. It rejects objects but still reifies consciousness.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: The targeted formulation denies external atoms.
- B: Incorrect: Yogācāra supplies a rich conventional causal psychology.
- C: Incorrect: Ālaya is conditioned, though Madhyamaka may still charge subtler reification.
- D: Correct: Object anti-realism remains incomplete while awareness retains intrinsic nature.

Examiner trap: The comparison must not caricature ālaya as ātman before presenting Madhyamaka's subtler objection.

MCQ 54. Nyāya and Buddhist self

Which issue most directly separates Nyāya's self from the Buddhist causal series?

- A. Nyāya denies memory while Buddhism accepts it.
- B. Nyāya requires an enduring owner; Buddhism uses conventionally unified causal events.
- C. Buddhism accepts an eternal witness inaccessible to Nyāya inference.
- D. Nyāya makes the self momentary while Buddhism makes it bodily.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Both explain memory but with different ontologies.
- B: Correct: The dispute is whether cross-temporal ownership requires numerical identity.
- C: Incorrect: Buddhism denies such a witness.
- D: Incorrect: Both descriptions are false.

Examiner trap: Merely contrasting 'self' and 'no-self' misses the shared explanandum of memory and responsibility.

MCQ 55. Cārvāka and Buddhist denials

How does Cārvāka's rejection of a transcendental self differ from Buddhist no-self?

- A. Buddhism denies embodiment while Cārvāka alone accepts perception.
- B. Cārvāka affirms a permanent material soul while Buddhism affirms a mental soul.
- C. Cārvāka ends consciousness with the body; Buddhism preserves karmic continuity without self.
- D. Cārvāka and Buddhism both deny consciousness after every moment.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Buddhism accepts embodiment and perception.
- B: Incorrect: Neither position is accurate.
- C: Correct: Both reject a transcendental ātman but diverge on reduction, rebirth and karma.
- D: Incorrect: Cārvāka is not committed to Buddhist momentariness.

Examiner trap: A comparison based only on shared denial cannot answer the printed demand for differentiation.

MCQ 56. Knowing absence

In the jar-absence debate, which contrast is most accurate?

- A. Both treat absence as a permanent universal directly perceived.
- B. Nyāya perceives real absence; Buddhism constructs it through non-apprehension and exclusion.
- C. Neither system permits valid cognition of absence.
- D. Buddhists treat absence as a substance while Nyāya treats it as fiction.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Buddhist ontology does not add such a universal category.
- B: Correct: The dispute concerns absence's ontology and its cognitive mechanism.
- C: Incorrect: Both explain ordinary absence judgements.
- D: Incorrect: This reverses the positions.

Examiner trap: Discussing only whether the jar is seen ignores the target cognition: qualified non-apprehension of it on the table.

MCQ 57. Pramāṇa and its result

Which formulation captures the Buddhist pressure on Nyāya's pramāṇa/pramāṇaphala distinction?

- A. Buddhism denies every distinction between cause and effect.
- B. Both systems make an eternal self the pramāṇa.
- C. Nyāya identifies every valid pramāṇa exclusively with authoritative testimony.
- D. Buddhism unifies cognition and result functionally; Nyāya distinguishes instrument from result.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: It denies reified separation here, not causal differentiation generally.
- B: Incorrect: Buddhism denies an eternal knower.
- C: Incorrect: Nyāya admits several means of knowledge.
- D: Correct: The dispute concerns cognition, result and the status of the knower.

Examiner trap: Counting pramāṇas without explaining pramāṇaphala misses the relational burden of the debate.

MCQ 58. The owner of memory objection

What is the strongest Nyāya objection to explaining memory by a causally connected series alone?

- A. Momentary events cannot cause later events under any conditions.
- B. Memory requires direct perception of the past object.
- C. Causal succession explains production, not first-person ownership of an earlier cognition.
- D. A causal series cannot contain any similarity between stages.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Buddhism's entire account affirms such causation.
- B: Incorrect: Memory is not analysed as present perception of a past object.
- C: Correct: The objection targets ownership and first-person unity, not bare production.
- D: Incorrect: Buddhism explicitly uses similarity alongside causation.

Examiner trap: Answering only with 'santāna' names the mechanism but does not meet the ownership challenge.

MCQ 59. Nyāya's power reply

How can Nyāya resist the Buddhist succession horn without claiming that the substance itself changes?

- A. It can identify every auxiliary with the permanent substance.
- B. An enduring substance may possess powers activated differently by changing auxiliaries.
- C. It can deny that causes ever produce effects.
- D. It can accept that the substance lasts for only one moment.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: This erases the explanatory conditions the reply invokes.
- B: Correct: The realist separates possession of a capacity from episodic exercise.
- C: Incorrect: That would abandon Nyāya causation.
- D: Incorrect: That directly concedes the Buddhist momentariness thesis.

Examiner trap: A fair critical answer states this reply before deploying the Buddhist redundancy/change counter-dilemma.

MCQ 60. Emptying consciousness

Why does Madhyamaka reject an ultimately self-established store-consciousness even if it explains continuity?

- A. Because a permanent personal self is preferable.
- B. Ālaya may work conventionally while remaining dependently arisen and empty.
- C. Because continuity is wholly unreal at the conventional level.
- D. Because only external matter can carry karmic seeds.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: That would contradict Buddhist no-self.
- B: Correct: A successful conventional posit is not thereby an ultimate foundation.
- C: Incorrect: Madhyamaka preserves conventional causal continuity.
- D: Incorrect: Madhyamaka does not restore material substantialism.

Examiner trap: Madhyamaka criticism need not deny ālaya's conventional role in order to deny its ultimacy.

MCQ 61. Shared worlds without external objects

What is Yogācāra's best reply to the claim that representation-only makes disagreement and shared experience impossible?

- A. Interacting karmic seed-streams can condition shared appearances without one private ego.
- B. Disagreement proves that no cognition has any validity.
- C. All persons are modes of one permanent cosmic subject.
- D. External objects are admitted whenever two observers agree.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: Shared constraint can be internally causal without being privately voluntary.
- B: Incorrect: The school distinguishes distorted construction from perfected cognition.
- C: Incorrect: This imports an absolute not required by Yogācāra.
- D: Incorrect: That abandons the thesis rather than defending it.

Examiner trap: 'Mind-only' is a claim about the structure of experience, not carte blanche for imagination.

MCQ 62. Pudgalavāda foil

Why is Pudgalavāda a revealing foil for mainstream Buddhist no-self?

- A. Pudgalavāda posits an ineffable aggregate-related person to secure agency and responsibility.
- B. It openly restores the Upaniṣadic eternal ātman as a sixth aggregate.
- C. It is a Madhyamaka name for the conventional person.
- D. It denies karma and rebirth because no person can continue.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: The position dramatizes the pressure between anti-substantialism and responsibility.
- B: Incorrect: Its person is deliberately not identified with such an ātman.
- C: Incorrect: It is a distinct doctrinal position criticized by other Buddhists.
- D: Incorrect: It introduces the pudgala precisely to secure these.

Examiner trap: Calling the pudgala simply 'the soul' misses both its intended indeterminacy and the force of the Buddhist criticism.

MCQ 63. Refuge without a soul

How can refuge in the Three Jewels remain consistent with no-self?

- A. Nirvāṇa is bestowed on a soul by the Buddha.
- B. Only the Saṅgha has a collective permanent self.
- C. The refuge formula temporarily suspends no-self for religious purposes.
- D. A conventional causal stream can learn, transform and take refuge without a soul.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: The Dharma is practised causally; liberation is not a gift to a substance.
- B: Incorrect: No collective ātman is required.
- C: Incorrect: The traditions present the commitments as mutually coherent.
- D: Correct: Functional agency at the conventional level is sufficient for refuge and training.

Examiner trap: Treating devotional language as proof of a metaphysical self confuses grammatical agency with substance.

MCQ 64. Historical overstatement

Which sentence commits a historical-layer error?

- A. A modern answer should identify when a proof belongs to later scholastic Buddhism.
- B. Early discourses teach impermanence without requiring every later scholastic argument.
- C. Later Buddhist logicians radicalize impermanence into a strict momentariness thesis.
- D. The earliest discourses teach Dharmakīrti's fully articulated causal-efficacy proof in its later technical form.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: This avoids projecting ownership backwards.
- B: Incorrect: This correctly distinguishes doctrine from later derivation.
- C: Incorrect: This is the relevant historical distinction.
- D: Correct: The mature technical proof is later even when it develops earlier premises.

Examiner trap: Doctrinal continuity does not license attribution of later vocabulary and argument form to the earliest layer.

MCQ 65. Not an arithmetic mean

A candidate writes that the Middle Path recommends 'half indulgence and half asceticism'. What is the precise defect?

- A. It confuses Mahāyāna with Theravāda.
- B. It makes the path too doctrinal and insufficiently practical.
- C. The Middle Path rejects extremes through an eightfold discipline.

D. It understates the amount of asceticism recommended.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: The error predates and cuts across that classification.
- B: Incorrect: The statement is already practical but philosophically misconceived.
- C: Correct: The middle is functionally specified, not averaged.
- D: Incorrect: The problem is not the proportion but the model of compromise.

Examiner trap: The Aristotelian-mean analogy is useful only if immediately qualified against arithmetic moderation.

MCQ 66. Representationalism is still realism

Which claim would turn Sautrāntika into a position it does not hold?

- A. Access may be indirect while existence remains mind-independent.
- B. Because only a representation is immediately known, no external cause exists at all.
- C. The external object is inferred from the cognition-form it caused.
- D. The cause precedes the cognition in a momentary sequence.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: This states the key distinction.
- B: Correct: Indirect epistemic access does not entail ontological idealism.
- C: Incorrect: This is Sautrāntika representational realism.
- D: Incorrect: This grounds the time-gap argument.

Examiner trap: Moving from 'not directly perceived' to 'nonexistent' is the exact illicit inference Yogācāra adds and Sautrāntika rejects.

MCQ 67. Emptiness is empty

What does 'the emptiness of emptiness' prevent?

- A. It reverses emptiness and restores substantial dharmas.
- B. It prevents any use of conventional language.
- C. It proves that only consciousness is ultimately real.
- D. Emptiness is itself dependent, preventing it from becoming an ultimate essence.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: No realist substrate is restored.
- B: Incorrect: Madhyamaka relies on convention to teach emptiness.
- C: Incorrect: That would reify the very candidate Madhyamaka criticizes.
- D: Correct: Emptiness is a dependent corrective designation, not an ontological ground.

Examiner trap: Writing 'everything rests on emptiness' converts a method of de-reification into metaphysical foundationalism.

MCQ 68. Answer-spine ordering

For a question asking how dependent origination proves momentariness, which answer sequence is strongest?

- A. Describe the Buddha's life → define nirvāṇa → compare Jainism → conclude.
- B. Define conditionality → derive impermanence → add causal efficacy → state simultaneity/succession horns → meet auxiliaries → preserve continuity.
- C. Define momentariness → list twelve links → assert that change is obvious → conclude.
- D. State causal efficacy → deny all continuity → call the result annihilationism.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: The material is largely irrelevant to the derivation.
- B: Correct: The sequence exposes every inferential bridge and the principal objection.
- C: Incorrect: This omits the added premise and the contested proof.
- D: Incorrect: This defeats the Buddhist reply and misclassifies the doctrine.

Examiner trap: A correct conclusion with a missing bridge does not satisfy 'logical derivative'.

MCQ 69. Ownership-sensitive school answer

Which introduction best frames a comparison of the four syllabus schools?

- A. All four teach the same no-self doctrine and differ only in terminology.
- B. Theravāda first split into Vaibhāṣika, Sautrāntika, Yogācāra and Madhyamaka.
- C. Buddhism evolved linearly from false realism to the final truth of Madhyamaka.
- D. Compare historically layered schools by objects, cognitive access and intrinsic nature.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Their accounts of dharmas, objects and consciousness differ substantially.
- B: Incorrect: The genealogy is historically false.
- C: Incorrect: This turns a comparison into an unargued triumphalist history.
- D: Correct: The frame distinguishes historical placement from philosophical comparison.

Examiner trap: Calling later schools 'stages' must not imply that each historically descended from the preceding syllabus row.

MCQ 70. Karma objection-reply structure

Which structure best answers a critical question on momentariness and karma?

- A. Present the ownership objection, causal-continuity reply, karmic mechanism and residual desert problem.

B. Deny that later consequences belong to anyone → call this liberation.

C. Introduce a permanent self to carry merit → defend momentariness separately.

D. Assert karma is a religious belief → cite rebirth → omit objections.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: A strong answer both reconstructs and evaluates the causal-continuity reply.
- B: Incorrect: That destroys responsibility rather than explaining it.
- C: Incorrect: This solves the problem by abandoning Buddhist no-self.
- D: Incorrect: The critical demand requires mechanism and evaluation.

Examiner trap: Stopping after the flame analogy leaves intention, ownership and moral desert unanalysed.

MCQ 71. Intervention at feeling

A practitioner experiences an unpleasant feeling. In twelve-link terms, where is the most immediate disciplined intervention?

A. Reverse birth directly while leaving craving intact.

B. Eliminate the six sense-bases by refusing all perception.

C. Mindfulness interrupts the feeling-to-craving condition, weakening clinging and becoming.

D. Find the first historical ignorance that began the series.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Birth is downstream and cannot be isolated from present causes.
- B: Incorrect: The path trains response rather than requiring sensory destruction.
- C: Correct: The feeling-to-craving junction makes conditionality practically actionable.
- D: Incorrect: The series is beginningless and practice targets presently operative conditions.

Examiner trap: A purely three-life reading can hide the present-moment point at which the path operates.

MCQ 72. Responsibility in a changing person

A court treats a reformed adult as responsible for an earlier act despite extensive psychological change. Which Buddhist analogy is strongest?

A. An eternal legal soul preserves every property unchanged.

B. The adult is numerically unrelated, so punishment necessarily targets a stranger.

C. Conventional identity is arbitrary, so any person could be punished.

D. Legal responsibility can follow causal continuity, memory and inherited dispositions without self-sameness.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Buddhist analysis neither needs nor permits such a soul.

- B: Incorrect: This ignores the conventionally continuous causal stream.
- C: Incorrect: Causal and evidential constraints prevent arbitrariness.
- D: Correct: Practical accountability can supervene on structured continuity rather than metaphysical sameness.

Examiner trap: Application earns marks only if the analogy preserves the Buddhist constraints instead of importing a hidden substance.

MCQ 73. Diagnosing a nirvāṇa answer

Which sentence should be deleted first from an answer defending nirvāṇa under no-self?

- A. A causal stream can undergo discipline without an additional owner.
- B. Conventional discourse may still say that a person is liberated.
- C. After liberation, the eternal subject possesses nirvāṇa as its unchanging private state.
- D. Nirvāṇa names cessation of greed, aversion and delusion.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: This meets the agency objection.
- B: Incorrect: Two-level language permits this without ultimate selfhood.
- C: Correct: The sentence simultaneously reifies subject, possession and state.
- D: Incorrect: This accurately states what is extinguished.

Examiner trap: The grammar 'one attains nirvāṇa' must be unpacked, not read as proof of an enduring possessor.

MCQ 74. PYQ 2018: dependence to emptiness

Which thesis is indispensable in a direct answer to the 2018 demand asking how Madhyamaka applies dependent origination to establish emptiness?

- A. Dependent things are unreal because only a permanent cause can be real.
- B. Whatever depends on causes and designation lacks svabhāva; emptiness is not non-being.
- C. Emptiness is inferred from the identity of cognition and object.
- D. The twelve links end in a transcendent substance called emptiness.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: This reinstates the substantial criterion Madhyamaka rejects.
- B: Correct: The answer must present the dependence-versus-independence inference and its anti-nihilist scope.
- C: Incorrect: That is a Yogācāra route, not the Madhyamaka derivation.
- D: Incorrect: Neither the links nor emptiness posit such a substance.

Examiner trap: Defining both terms separately without the inferential bridge does not answer 'apply'.

MCQ 75. PYQ 2018: no-self and nirvāṇa

What is the strongest consistency defence for no-self and nirvāṇa?

- A. Nirvāṇa annihilates the self after it completes practice.
- B. A permanent self appears only at liberation.
- C. No-self removes appropriation; nirvāṇa ceases that process rather than rewarding a self.
- D. No-self is conventional but an eternal subject is ultimate.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Annihilation presupposes the self that Buddhism never admitted.
- B: Incorrect: This makes liberation contradict the path's central insight.
- C: Correct: The two doctrines are mutually supporting once liberation is analysed processually.
- D: Incorrect: This reverses Buddhist two-level analysis.

Examiner trap: Calling them merely 'compatible' misses the stronger causal relation between insight into no-self and cessation.

MCQ 76. PYQ 2019: external world

Which answer set directly satisfies the 2019 Yogācāra 'how' demand?

- A. List the five aggregates and explain personal no-self.
- B. Assert that one private mind creates whatever it wishes.
- C. Dream, atom and time-gap arguments challenge externality; karmic seeds explain shared order.
- D. Only define vijñaptimātra and state that matter is illusion.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: That addresses a different doctrine.
- B: Incorrect: This is the crude idealism the school rejects.
- C: Correct: The arguments divide evidential, coherence and explanatory labour, followed by an order-preserving reply.
- D: Incorrect: A definition without arguments does not answer 'how'.

Examiner trap: A dream-only answer is incomplete and vulnerable to the waking-order objection.

MCQ 77. PYQ 2019: apply dependence to momentariness

Which conditional sub-argument best performs the 2019 demand to apply dependent origination to momentariness?

- A. A permanent producer either acts all at once or changes with conditions.
- B. A dependent thing must have a first unconditioned material cause that remains identical.
- C. A momentary event cannot condition another event because it has already ceased.
- D. A changing thing is momentary simply because both words exclude eternity.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: The application must run the simultaneity-succession and auxiliary-condition dilemma against permanent causal efficacy.
- B: Incorrect: This replaces dependent origination with the substantial first cause it rejects.
- C: Incorrect: Buddhist causal succession treats the prior event's efficacy as conditioning the next.
- D: Incorrect: Shared opposition to permanence does not establish one-moment duration.

Examiner trap: This question tests the operative derivation, whereas the 2020 probe tests how strongly that derivation may be described.

MCQ 78. PYQ 2020: logical derivative

Which critical qualification belongs in the 2020 'logical derivative' answer?

- A. The derivation succeeds only by accepting a permanent efficient cause.
- B. The two doctrines are unrelated and merely historically adjacent.
- C. Momentariness follows only through the explicit premise that reality is causal efficacy.
- D. Dependent origination already literally states one-moment duration.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: The argument targets precisely such permanence.
- B: Incorrect: The later proof develops dependence and impermanence in a stricter form.
- C: Correct: The logical claim requires its mediating causal-efficacy premise.
- D: Incorrect: The canonical formula does not state that technical thesis.

Examiner trap: A sophisticated answer distinguishes 'derivative' from 'verbatim contained in'.

MCQ 79. PYQ 2020: aggregates and liberation

Which answer move connects the two halves of the 2020 aggregates-and-liberation demand?

- A. Liberation transforms and ceases the aggregate stream, not a separate sixth entity.
- B. Conclude that no one practises and therefore liberation is impossible.
- C. After listing five aggregates, introduce consciousness as their permanent owner.
- D. Treat liberation as destruction of the physical aggregate alone.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: The same exhaustive analysis that denies the self must explain the locus of practice.
- B: Incorrect: The conventional person remains causally operative.
- C: Incorrect: Consciousness is itself one conditioned aggregate.
- D: Incorrect: Craving and ignorance concern the whole psycho-physical process.

Examiner trap: Listing aggregates without returning to the liberation question answers only half the paper demand.

MCQ 80. PYQ 2021: two no-selves

Which distinction directly answers the 2021 question?

- A. The first is Madhyamaka and the second is early Theravāda.
- B. They are exact synonyms used by different languages.
- C. Personal no-self denies an aggregate-owner; dharma no-self denies intrinsic nature universally.
- D. The first denies matter and the second denies mind.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: The historical and doctrinal direction is wrong.
- B: Incorrect: Their scope differs and generates school distinctions.
- C: Correct: One analysis removes the owner and the other radicalizes analysis of the inventory.
- D: Incorrect: The distinction is person versus constituent phenomena, not matter versus mind.

Examiner trap: A two-column answer must include scope and school significance, not only translations.

MCQ 81. PYQ 2021: memory and identity

Which response best meets the 'critically discuss' clause in the 2021 memory question?

- A. Use ālaya as the universal Buddhist answer without historical qualification.
- B. Use causal dispositions and conventional identity, then assess the unresolved ownership objection.
- C. Deny that memory occurs because all cognitions perish.
- D. State that memory proves a permanent self and abandon momentariness.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Ālaya is Yogācāra-specific, not the shared early account.
- B: Correct: Critical discussion requires mechanism, historical care and residual pressure.
- C: Incorrect: The phenomenon is accepted and requires explanation.
- D: Incorrect: This gives the opponent's conclusion without the Buddhist reply.

Examiner trap: The flame analogy is illustrative evidence, not by itself an analysis of recollective ownership.

MCQ 82. PYQ 2022: momentariness and karma

Which proposition best answers the compatibility issue in the 2022 karma question?

- A. Momentariness means consequences are random because causes perish.
- B. The doctrine is compatible only if rebirth is denied.
- C. Karma requires a permanent soul, so Buddhism secretly accepts one.

D. Karma uses causal inheritance, while deserved ownership remains the central objection.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: A cause can perish after transmitting efficacy.
- B: Incorrect: Rebirth is among the phenomena the continuity account explains.
- C: Incorrect: This abandons the explicit Buddhist solution.
- D: Correct: Causal transmission supplies continuity while moral ownership remains the evaluative pressure point.

Examiner trap: Compatibility should not be asserted before reconstructing the strongest desert objection.

MCQ 83. PYQ 2022: Three Jewels

Which relation-and-consistency claim best answers the 2022 Triratna demand?

- A. Each Jewel independently grants liberation to an eternal devotee.
- B. The Saṅgha creates the Dharma by collective agreement.
- C. Functionally related Jewels guide a conventional practitioner-stream without requiring an immutable soul.
- D. No-self makes refuge grammatically and causally impossible.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: This breaks both internal relation and no-self.
- B: Incorrect: Transmission does not mean doctrinal creation.
- C: Correct: The answer needs both functional interrelation and a no-self consistency defence.
- D: Incorrect: Conventional agency is sufficient for instruction and transformation.

Examiner trap: Explaining only the three names leaves the explicit critical half unanswered.

MCQ 84. PYQ 2023: soteriology through conditionality

Why can ignorance of dependent origination be called suffering and knowledge of it cessation?

- A. Knowledge magically erases past events from existence.
- B. Ignorance is the unconditioned first cause of the universe.
- C. Insight removes self-misapprehension, thereby weakening craving and its downstream conditions.
- D. Knowledge reveals a permanent self untouched by suffering.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Cessation concerns renewed production, not retroactive deletion.
- B: Incorrect: It is conditioned and analysed within the cycle.
- C: Correct: Epistemic transformation is soteriological because misapprehension is itself a causal condition.
- D: Incorrect: This contradicts the insight being described.

Examiner trap: A twelve-link list scores poorly unless it shows where knowledge reverses the mechanism.

MCQ 85. PYQ 2024: real and void

How can 'everything is real' and 'everything is void' arise from dependent origination without being simple contradiction?

- A. Vaibhāṣika affirms functioning dharmas; Madhyamaka denies intrinsic nature to dependent phenomena.
- B. Vaibhāṣika and Madhyamaka use the words with identical meanings but one makes a factual error.
- C. Madhyamaka rejects dependent origination entirely, whereas Vaibhāṣika alone accepts conditioned arising.
- D. The opposition is mainly between Theravāda discipline and Mahāyāna ritual practice.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: The conclusion depends on each school's distinct criterion of reality.
- B: Incorrect: The question requires reconstructing distinct inferential frameworks.
- C: Incorrect: Both appeal to dependence, though they interpret its ontology differently.
- D: Incorrect: The demand is philosophical and school-specific.

Examiner trap: Writing 'everything is void' without naming svabhāva makes Madhyamaka look like simple nonexistence.

MCQ 86. PYQ 2025: nirvāṇa with two denials

Which synthesis best addresses nirvāṇa's consonance with momentariness and no-self?

- A. Nirvāṇa is the annihilation of a momentary soul.
- B. Mutable conditioned processes can cease, without nirvāṇa becoming a permanent subject's possession.
- C. No-self is suspended at liberation so that someone can enjoy it.
- D. Momentariness applies to nirvāṇa as a rapidly vanishing pleasure.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: A soul is not admitted, momentary or permanent.
- B: Correct: Both doctrines positively support a process account of liberation.
- C: Incorrect: This creates the contradiction the question asks the candidate to resolve.
- D: Incorrect: Nirvāṇa is not one more conditioned hedonic event.

Examiner trap: Treating 'unconditioned' as 'eternal substance' is the central category mistake.

MCQ 87. PYQ 2026: action and responsibility

What should the 2026 answer identify as the unresolved critical issue after presenting Buddhist causal continuity?

- A. Whether a creator assigns consequences to each soul.
- B. Test whether inherited intention secures desert without numerical personal identity.

C. Whether the Vedas authorize karmic responsibility.

D. Whether momentary events can ever occur in temporal order.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: The Buddhist explanation avoids both creator and soul.
- B: Correct: The strongest evaluation distinguishes successful transmission from contested ownership.
- C: Incorrect: Vedic authority is not the basis of the account.
- D: Incorrect: Buddhism affirms ordered causal succession.

Examiner trap: Repeating 'neither same nor different' without applying it to desert leaves the critical directive unmet.

MCQ 88. Supporting PYQ: absence

What two axes must structure the supporting 2018 Buddhism-Nyāya absence answer?

- A. Whether both schools deny all negative facts.
- B. Whether inference is valid and scripture is eternal.
- C. Whether jars are substances and tables are universals.
- D. Separate absence's ontology from its perceptual or constructed cognition.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Nyāya explicitly affirms absence as a category.
- B: Incorrect: The comparison is more specific than general epistemology.
- C: Incorrect: Those classifications do not isolate absence cognition.
- D: Correct: Ontology and epistemology must be compared separately before the verdict.

Examiner trap: Answering only 'the jar is not seen' fails to distinguish bare non-seeing from cognition of absence.

MCQ 89. Supporting PYQ: two self denials

Which contrast is mandatory in the supporting 2024 Cārvāka-Buddhist self question?

- A. Both preserve rebirth through an eternal material soul.
- B. Cārvāka ends embodied consciousness; Buddhism retains karmic rebirth through causal continuity.
- C. Buddhism reduces consciousness to the four gross elements exactly as Cārvāka does.
- D. Cārvāka accepts karma while Buddhism rejects it.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Neither claim is correct.
- B: Correct: Shared anti-transcendentalism must be followed by different positive accounts.
- C: Incorrect: Buddhist aggregates and causal analysis are not Cārvāka material reduction.

- D: Incorrect: The positions are reversed.

Examiner trap: A common conclusion does not imply common premises or consequences.

MCQ 90. Supporting PYQ: instrument and result

What is the conceptual centre of the supporting 2025 Nyāya-Buddhist debate?

- A. Whether absence must be admitted as a separate seventh ontological category.
- B. Whether every inferential cognition must be rejected as inherently uncertain.
- C. Whether authoritative testimony alone can establish every possible object of knowledge.
- D. Compare whether cognition, result and knower are distinct entities or momentary functions.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: That belongs to a different Nyāya-Buddhist dispute.
- B: Incorrect: Buddhist epistemologists accept inference.
- C: Incorrect: The debate is not confined to testimony.
- D: Correct: The central issue is whether cognition, result and knower are distinct.

Examiner trap: A list of two versus four pramāṇas does not answer the pramāṇaphala half.

MCQ 91. Two truths are not two realities

Which reading of Madhyamaka's two truths is correct?

- A. Ultimate truth is a hidden object perceived after conventions disappear.
- B. They are two separate worlds, one false and one permanently real.
- C. Both truths describe dependently arisen phenomena as functional yet empty of svabhāva.
- D. Conventional truth is sheer error with no role in liberation.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Ultimate analysis finds no self-grounded object.
- B: Incorrect: This spatializes and substantializes an epistemic-ontological distinction.
- C: Correct: The distinction does not multiply reality into two ontological realms.
- D: Incorrect: The path and teaching operate through convention.

Examiner trap: Calling ultimate truth 'higher reality' risks turning emptiness into the substrate it denies.

MCQ 92. Ālaya under pressure

Which pair states both the explanatory gain and philosophical risk of ālaya-vijñāna?

- A. Ālaya carries seeds through change but cannot be a self-established subject.

- B. It proves external atoms; its risk is direct realism.
- C. It abolishes karma; its risk is moral fatalism.
- D. It is an eternal witness; its risk is that it changes.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: A complete evaluation pairs functional success with anti-reification caution.
- B: Incorrect: Ālaya belongs to representation-only, not atom realism.
- C: Incorrect: It is introduced partly to explain karmic continuity.
- D: Incorrect: Its conditioned change is essential, not an accidental risk.

Examiner trap: Calling ālaya either simply 'self' or simply 'not-self' without its role and risk is analytically thin.

MCQ 93. Arhat and bodhisattva ideals

Which comparison preserves the historical nuance between arhat and bodhisattva ideals?

- A. The contrast identifies dominant aims, not mutually exclusive vocabularies or a selfish-versus-altruistic binary.
- B. Theravāda rejects every bodhisattva career, while Mahāyāna rejects the category of arhat.
- C. Arhat and bodhisattva are interchangeable names for one institutional rank in every Buddhist school.
- D. The bodhisattva merely delays an otherwise identical arhat goal until all beings are liberated.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: The contrast marks dominant normative orientation while preserving cross-traditional vocabulary and historical complexity.
- B: Incorrect: Both traditions know the other category even while foregrounding different ideals.
- C: Incorrect: Their normative functions and historical prominence differ across traditions.
- D: Incorrect: Mahāyāna redirects the final aim toward complete Buddhahood, not simple postponement.

Examiner trap: Do not caricature the arhat as selfish or the bodhisattva as merely postponing the same final goal.

MCQ 94. Definition of perception

How do Dignāga and Dharmakīrti jointly define valid Buddhist perception?

- A. Both count every vivid appearance as valid perception, including illusion.
- B. Dignāga makes perception conceptual, and Dharmakīrti restricts it to testimony.
- C. Dignāga defines perception as inference, and Dharmakīrti adds universal recognition.
- D. Dignāga excludes conceptual construction, and Dharmakīrti also excludes erroneous non-conceptual appearance.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: The abhṛānta condition excludes vivid but mistaken appearances.

- B: Incorrect: Both retain direct non-conceptual awareness rather than testimony.
- C: Incorrect: Inference and universals belong to conceptual cognition.
- D: Correct: Kalpanāpoḍha removes conceptual construction, while abhrānta removes non-conceptual error.

Examiner trap: Non-conceptuality alone would wrongly validate a double moon or a whirling-firebrand circle.

MCQ 95. Four kinds of perception

Which list gives the fourfold perception division in the Buddhist pramāṇa tradition?

- A. Sense perception, mental perception, cognition's self-awareness and disciplined yogic perception.
- B. External perception, universal perception, scriptural perception and recollection.
- C. Sense perception, inference, comparison and testimony.
- D. Visual perception, auditory perception, touch and conceptual judgement.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: The division comprises indriya, mānasa, svasaṃvedana and yogi-pratyakṣa.
- B: Incorrect: Universals, testimony and memory are not the four perceptual divisions.
- C: Incorrect: That mixes perception with independently classified means of knowledge.
- D: Incorrect: This omits mental, reflexive and yogic perception while adding conceptual judgement.

Examiner trap: Do not replace the four perceptual modes with Nyāya's list of four pramāṇas.

MCQ 96. Mīmāṃsā enduring-agent objection

How does Buddhism answer the Mīmāṃsā claim that one enduring agent must perform, own and later receive the result of an action?

- A. Agency is unreal, so no intention or later result needs an owner or explanation.
- B. The same permanent knower remains unchanged while actions and results occur around it.
- C. A universal called agency migrates between momentary cognitions and unifies them.
- D. A causally connected cognition-stream can inherit intentions and results without one numerically identical agent persisting throughout.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Buddhism retains conventional agency, karma and responsibility.
- B: Incorrect: That concedes the enduring subject Buddhism is defending its analysis against.
- C: Incorrect: Universals are not migrating subjects or bearers of karmic inheritance.
- D: Correct: Causal inheritance supplies diachronic ownership without converting the stream into a substance.

Examiner trap: Do not answer this agency objection with apoha, which addresses general word-meaning rather than action ownership.

MCQ 97. Mīmāṃsā universals objection

How does Buddhist apoha answer the Mīmāṃsā objection that words require positive, repeatable universals?

- A. Exclusion and recurrent causal capacities stabilize word-use without positive universals.
- B. A permanent speaker-self creates universals whenever a word is uttered.
- C. Each word directly perceives an eternal universal present identically in all particulars.
- D. Words have no repeatable use because only unique particulars exist.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: Exclusion plus convergent causal practice explains positive-seeming classification without reifying a universal.
- B: Incorrect: The dispute concerns semantic generality, not creation by an enduring speaker.
- C: Incorrect: This states the positive-universal theory that apoha rejects.
- D: Incorrect: Apoha explains usable generality rather than abandoning linguistic practice.

Examiner trap: Do not substitute the separate enduring-agent reply for the semantic operation demanded here.

MCQ 98. Advaita synchronic-unity objection

How can Buddhism answer Advaita's claim that simultaneous features of one experience require a single witness-consciousness?

- A. A permanent witness is admitted conventionally but denied only after liberation.
- B. Unity is impossible, because every momentary cognition is wholly unrelated to every other.
- C. Mutually conditioning cognitions and reflexive awareness can integrate one episode without an invariant witness standing behind it.
- D. Store-consciousness is the changeless witness that illuminates all simultaneous contents.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: That grants the substantial witness the objection seeks to establish.
- B: Incorrect: Buddhist streams are causally and functionally connected.
- C: Correct: Functional integration and self-presentation explain synchronic unity without a second, unchanging observer.
- D: Incorrect: Ālaya is a conditioned changing stream, not Advaita's sākṣin.

Examiner trap: Do not answer a synchronic binding problem only with rebirth or long-term karmic continuity.

MCQ 99. Advaita diachronic-liberation objection

How does Buddhism answer Advaita's claim that bondage and liberation must belong to one enduring subject across time?

- A. Liberation creates a permanent self that retrospectively owned every prior moment.
- B. Brahman alone is liberated, while the Buddhist stream disappears without causal consequence.
- C. No-self makes bondage and liberation wholly unrelated, so practice cannot transform a life.

D. A conventionally identified causal continuum can undergo bondage and cessation without a numerically identical self owning both states.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: This invents the substance whose necessity is disputed.
- B: Incorrect: This imports the Advaita conclusion instead of giving the Buddhist reply.
- C: Incorrect: Causal continuity is retained precisely to explain transformation.
- D: Correct: Diachronic transformation requires causal dependence and conventional identity, not an invariant possessor.

Examiner trap: Do not use reflexive awareness alone; the question asks who is transformed across a sequence.

MCQ 100. Creator regress

What regress problem arises when a creator's purposive act is used to explain the world?

- A. Creation is impossible because effects never depend on causes.
- B. A creator cannot be inferred because every inference requires direct perception of its conclusion.
- C. Divine will merely relocates the question of what explains purposive creation.
- D. A creator must be one of the five aggregates and therefore bodily.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Buddhism affirms conditional causation.
- B: Incorrect: Inference need not directly perceive its conclusion; the objection targets explanatory termination.
- C: Correct: Appeal to divine will may relocate rather than terminate the demand for explanation.
- D: Incorrect: The regress does not depend on classifying God as a person-aggregate.

Examiner trap: Keep regress distinct from the moral partiality problem and from simple explanatory redundancy.

MCQ 101. Creator partiality

What is the distinct partiality objection to a benevolent creator?

- A. Divine partiality follows merely from the creator being timeless.
- B. Every unequal outcome proves that causal regularity is absent.
- C. A creator is partial only if embodied in one social group.
- D. Unequal outcomes imply arbitrary creation unless karma constrains and limits divine authorship.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Timelessness raises a change problem, not by itself the moral distribution problem.
- B: Incorrect: Buddhism explains differentiated outcomes through karmic and natural conditions.
- C: Incorrect: The objection concerns unequal distribution of suffering, not embodiment.
- D: Correct: Unequal outcomes force a choice between arbitrary authorship and karmic constraint.

Examiner trap: Do not substitute the separate regress or redundancy arguments for the partiality challenge.

MCQ 102. Time-gap argument

What is the distinct Yogācāra use of the time gap between external cause and cognition?

- A. The expired external cause is explanatorily idle when only cognition presents the form.
- B. Because atoms cannot have parts, the external object cannot be composed.
- C. Because dreams are vivid, every waking cognition is false.
- D. Because cognition is delayed, it must belong to a permanent self.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: The time-gap argument targets the external cause's explanatory role rather than the object's composition.
- B: Incorrect: That is the separate atom-composition argument.
- C: Incorrect: The dream argument questions evidence from appearance but does not establish universal falsity.
- D: Incorrect: The argument does not infer an enduring subject.

Examiner trap: Do not merge it with the atom critique merely because both pressure external realism.

MCQ 103. No-self and nirvāṇa

What resolves the apparent inconsistency between no-self and nirvāṇa?

- A. Liberation is cessation within a causal stream, not a permanent subject acquiring an everlasting property.
- B. Nirvāṇa belongs only to the Buddha and not to practitioners.
- C. A self is created at the final moment to receive liberation.
- D. The pre-liberation self is annihilated after completing the path.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: Processual cessation removes the need for an enduring possessor of liberation.
- B: Incorrect: The path is presented as practicable liberation for conditioned persons.
- C: Incorrect: This makes nirvāṇa depend on the substance Buddhism denies.
- D: Incorrect: Annihilation presupposes a self that no-self never admitted.

Examiner trap: Keep this problem separate from whether a no-self practitioner can take refuge in the Three Jewels.

MCQ 104. Scope of the three marks

Which scope statement about the three marks is most accurate?

- A. Not-self applies only to persons, whereas every dharma has a permanent core.
- B. Conditioned formations are impermanent and painful; not-self has wider scope.

C. Nirvāṇa must be momentary because everything without self is conditioned.

D. All three marks apply only to physical objects and never to cognition.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Buddhist analysis extends absence of selfhood beyond a personal ego.
- B: Correct: The scope distinction prevents no-self from converting unconditioned cessation into a conditioned moment.
- C: Incorrect: Important Buddhist traditions classify nirvāṇa as unconditioned.
- D: Incorrect: The marks centrally analyse psycho-physical experience.

Examiner trap: Do not infer that the wider reach of not-self makes every object impermanent in exactly the same classificatory sense.

MCQ 105. Canon and language caution

Which statement is historically safest about Buddhist canons and languages?

- A. Language alone determines whether a doctrine is Mahāyāna or non-Mahāyāna.
- B. Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika use the Theravāda Pāli canon as their sole authority.
- C. Buddhist materials survive across Pāli, Sanskrit, Chinese, Tibetan and fragmentary witnesses.
- D. All early Buddhist discourse is uniquely Pāli and all Mahāyāna teaching is uniquely Sanskrit.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Language is an orientation clue, not an exhaustive doctrinal test.
- B: Incorrect: Their textual histories are substantially preserved through other traditions.
- C: Correct: Historical placement requires a multilingual transmission model rather than a Pāli-versus-Sanskrit equation.
- D: Incorrect: Parallel Āgamas and translation histories defeat that binary.

Examiner trap: Do not infer school identity solely from the language in which a text survives.

MCQ 106. Recognition by similarity

How does similarity contribute to the Buddhist explanation of recognition without an enduring object?

- A. Recognition is always invalid because no relation can connect different moments.
- B. A later causal phase resembles an earlier phase closely enough for conventional recognition without numerical identity.
- C. The identical earlier object survives unchanged and is directly encountered again.
- D. A permanent universal remembers each object and transfers its identity to later stages.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Buddhism explains the judgement through causal succession and resemblance.
- B: Correct: Sādrśya explains the content of sameness-judgements while santāna explains temporal connection.
- C: Incorrect: That restores the persistence the momentary-stream account denies.

- D: Incorrect: Universals do not function as remembering subjects.

Examiner trap: Do not merge resemblance with causal continuity: one explains likeness, the other historical linkage.

MCQ 107. Can empty words deny emptiness?

How does Madhyamaka answer the charge that denying every thesis is itself a self-refuting thesis?

- A. Its denial is conventionally operative but empty of intrinsic authority, like one dependent construction undoing another.
- B. It abandons reasoning and relies solely on ineffable mystical experience.
- C. It asserts all four *catuṣkoṭi* alternatives together as a higher contradiction.
- D. It makes the denial an ultimately true substance exempt from emptiness.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: Empty, non-implicative discourse can remove reification without installing an independent counter-thesis.
- B: Incorrect: *Prasaṅga* remains a rigorous conventional argumentative practice.
- C: Incorrect: The corners are rejected under the *svabhāva* presupposition, not jointly affirmed.
- D: Incorrect: That would reify the corrective statement and concede the objection.

Examiner trap: The reply must explain the status of the denial itself, not merely repeat that all things are empty.

MCQ 108. Complete path grouping

Which allocation of the Eightfold Path is correct?

- A. Wisdom: right view/intention; ethics: right speech/action/livelihood; meditation: right effort/mindfulness/concentration.
- B. Wisdom: view alone; ethics: speech/action; meditation: all remaining factors.
- C. All eight belong equally to meditation because the path is contemplative.
- D. Wisdom: view and speech; ethics: intention and action; meditation: livelihood, effort, mindfulness and concentration.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: The three trainings organize all eight factors without residue.
- B: Incorrect: The classical grouping is not distributed this way.
- C: Incorrect: Conduct and understanding are irreducible trainings.
- D: Incorrect: Speech and livelihood are ethical, while intention belongs to wisdom.

Examiner trap: Remembering only the ethical triad does not demonstrate mastery of the complete architecture.

MCQ 109. Rebirth without transmigration

Which analogy least misleadingly represents Buddhist rebirth?

- A. A traveller leaving one house and entering another unchanged.

- B. A creator assigning a new body to the same soul.
- C. A jewel temporarily hidden in different boxes.
- D. One lamp lights another without a numerically identical flame migrating.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: This implies a persisting bearer that transmigrates.
- B: Incorrect: Both creator and soul are foreign to the account.
- C: Incorrect: This posits an invariant inner entity.
- D: Correct: Reconnection preserves dependence while denying transmigration of a substance.

Examiner trap: Even the lamp analogy must be explained causally; resemblance alone cannot secure karmic linkage.

MCQ 110. Dependence has different school uses

Which contrast shows why one premise can support Vaibhāṣika realism and Madhyamaka emptiness?

- A. Vaibhāṣika accepts causation while Madhyamaka rejects it.
- B. Madhyamaka makes every cause permanent while Vaibhāṣika makes it mental.
- C. The schools differ only over terminology for the same ultimate entities.
- D. Vaibhāṣika tests causal efficacy; Madhyamaka tests whether dependent things have svabhāva.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: Madhyamaka's argument begins from dependent causation.
- B: Incorrect: Neither description is accurate.
- C: Incorrect: Their criteria and ontological conclusions differ.
- D: Correct: Causal efficacy and intrinsic nature are distinct tests of reality.

Examiner trap: The 2024 comparison is not solved by saying one school is optimistic and the other pessimistic.